



PRIZED POSSESSION: (clockwise from left) Paintings by Ramanujam; Chowdhury; Souza; Khanna and Goud on display



Abraham who turns 80 in February.

As a tribute to the grand woman of Indian contemporary art, there will be a special show of her personal collection of paintings, drawings and sculptures at the Sumukha Art Gallery in Chennai. This is the first time she has allowed a display of her collection, but she's not happy about her treasure leaving home. "I know it's (the show) a good idea, but I feel insecure when they leave my walls."



It took a lot of coaxing and pleading by her protégé and gallery owner Premilla Baid for Abraham to put her collection of 200-odd works on display. "She agreed to the Chennai show after much persuasion, but I couldn't convince her to let the show travel to any other city," says Baid. Art lovers in Chennai will get to see, not just a rare and never-seen-before collection of the great masters in Indian art, but also a range of works and styles by individual artists, like the simple sketches of crow by Subramanyam, along with brilliant oils on canvas that are from a different phase in the artist's life. Then there is the magnificent oil on canvas, titled Lotus Pond, as well as a series of water colours of tropical foliage done by Ramachandran. Other artists on display are Ganesh Haloi, Ganesh Pyne, Laloo Prasad Shaw, Vishwanathan, Jogen

Chowdhury, Vivan Sundaram, Gogi Saroj Pal, Janki Ram, Krishan Khanna, Meera Mukherjee and the late Dharamnarayan Dasgupta in an impressive list. Besides, there is a series of oleographs in their original frames depicting the crucifixion of Christ and letters written by Goud to Abraham. Also, part of the show is a 4x3 family portrait of the Abrahams by Bhattacharya. "It was his own idea, he used to observe my family members, and one day he brought this wonderful work and gave it to me, and when I insisted on paying, he said Rs 10,000 would suffice."

Abraham's collection includes her own drawings, sketches and portraits, some of which are autographed by the subjects, including Albert Einstein, Jawaharlal Nehru and Lord Mountbatten, but the value of the works lies in her friendship with the artists of post-Independence India, especially

Husain, whom she rates as the finest Indian artist. "He is very disappointed that he cannot come for my 80th birthday and show," she sighs. The first Husain she bought was Miriam and the Mullah, which is her favourite. It was, in fact, Husain, who convinced her to start a Gallery and thus was born Kalayatra, Abraham's travelling exhibition in the early '60s. "Art was not fashionable in those days. We had to make it fashionable." This she did by creating venues for exhibitions in five-star hotels, something unheard of till Abraham started the trend. It was only many years later that she opened a permanent gallery in Bangalore, which she ran till 1998. "I wanted to do for art what Rukmini Devi Arundale had done for Bharatanatyam," she adds. And, to her credit she did all that and more. As a pioneer, promoter and leading artist, she is known, but not so much as a collector since she has been reluctant to show it to the world. Come February 9, that will change when she lifts the veil from one of the most rare and valuable collections in the country. ■



VIBRANT: Crows by Subramanyam